

The Oval portrait

• Frame Narrative

Frame narrative is a technique where a story is included within another story. The initial story that prepare content is called Frame narrative. And the story included inside Frame narrative is called main narrative.

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In the Frame narrative of this story, ~~an~~ we can see the injured narrator break into a chateau along with his valet and finds a book on the pillow about the painting. In the main narrative the story about the oval portrait is narrated. It has a story about the obsession about an artists who kills his wife because of it.

• Theme

- Obsession

- Art versus Life

- Destructive relationship between Art and Life.

Symbols

↳ The word phrase or object that has an indirect meaning is called symbol

- The chateau symbolises isolation and fear.
- The oval portrait symbolises eternal life of art.
- Frame symbolises imprisonment of beauty
- The Artist symbolises extreme obsession.
- The oval shape symbolises life's circular nature.
- The maiden symbolises victim of obsession.

Understanding the text

Answer these questions.

Q) Where did the narrator and his servant make forcible entrance?

Ans) The narrator and his servant forced their way into an old, abandoned castle in mountains of Italy. The narrator was badly wounded and needed a safe place to rest. As there was no other shelter nearby, they broke into the empty chateau (castle). The building was dark, lonely and in poor condition, but it looked safe enough for them to stay for the night in a small, decorated room.

b) Which special picture did the narrator notice in the room?

Ans. The narrator noticed a special oval-shaped ~~port~~ portrait of a young woman hanging on the wall. This picture was different from other paintings because it looked very real and lifelike. The woman's face looked bright and natural, as if she was alive. The beauty and realism of the painting surprised him and made him stare at it carefully. It was the most noticeable painting in the room.

c) Describe the portrait that the narrator saw in the room.

Ans. The portrait was an oval painting of a beautiful young woman. Her face looked soft, ~~gentle~~ gentle, and full of life. The eyes looked very real and expressive. The colours and light in the painting made it look natural and alive. The painting was so realistic that it shocked the narrator and made him feel uneasy. It looked as if the woman in the picture was alive and watching him.

d. What is the relationship between the portrait painter and its subject?

Ans. The portrait painter and the woman in the painting were husband and wife. The painter loved his art more than anything else, even more than his wife. The woman was kind and patient and sat quietly for many days while he painted her. As he worked harder to complete the painting, her health became worse. In the end, she died and the painter lost her forever.

Reference to the Content.

a. What is the central theme of the story?

Who is the ~~man~~ woman depicted in the oval portrait?

Ans. The main idea of "The Oval portrait" is that too much love for art can harm real life. The story teaches us that when someone becomes too focused on their work or passion, they may forget to care for the people they love. Art is important, but it should never be more important than life itself.

The woman in the portrait is a young, beautiful bride who loves her very husband very much. She is cheerful, kind

and full of life. She can do anything for her husband to receive her husband's attention and love. She agrees to sit for her husband so he can paint her portrait.

As the husband works harder to capture her beauty, she slowly becomes weaker and loses her health. In the end, she dies, and her spirit seems to live on only in the painting, showing how art took her life away.

b) "The Oval Portrait" is a short horror story by Edgar Allan Poe involving the disturbing circumstances surrounding a portrait in a chateau. Elaborate.

Ans. "The Oval Portrait" is a horror story because it creates a scary and mysterious mood. The story happens in an old, broken castle full of darkness and silence, which feels eerie and frightening. The setting of this story is a chateau in Appennings. The chateau/castle is broken, empty and full of shadows, which makes the narrator-and the reader-feel uneasy and scared. The silence and loneliness add to the feeling of mystery and fear, making it a perfect place for a horror story.

classmate
Date _____
Page _____

The painting in the story adds to the horror. It looks so real and alive that it confuses and frightens the narrator.

The story's main source of horror is the portrait itself. The painting of the young woman looks so real that it almost seems alive. This strange and unnatural lifelike quality of the painting is creepy.

The most terrifying moment is the story's shocking ending. When the painter finishes the portrait, he proudly claims it is alive, but then the narrator realizes the woman in the portrait is actually dead. This sudden and tragic truth surprises the reader and gives the story its dark and horrifying twist.

c) "The Oval Portrait" suggests that the woman's beauty condemns her to death. Discuss.

Ans The story shows that the woman's beauty causes her death. Because she is so beautiful, her husband wants to paint her perfectly. His desire to capture her beauty makes him ignore her health and feelings.

She sits in a dark room for many hours every day, quietly and patiently, while he paints. She becomes weaker and ~~patiently~~ paler with each passing day but does not complain because she loves him. Her

beauty turns her into an object for artistic perfection rather than a human being who needs care and attention.

In the end, her beauty becomes her curse. The painter becomes so obsessed with creating a perfect image of her beauty that he forgets to care about her life. When the portrait is finished, her life fades away completely. This shows that her beauty "condemns" her, because it makes her husband value the painting more than her life, leading directly to her death.

d) Discuss the story as a frame narrative (a story within a story).

Ans. "The Oval Portrait" is told as a frame narrative, which means it has a story inside another story. The outer story is about a wounded narrator and his servant who enter an old abandoned castle to find shelter for the night. This part introduces the dark setting and creates a mysterious mood. The narrator ~~the~~ notices strange paintings decorating the walls, which makes him curious about them.

Inside this main story, there is another story. The narrator finds a book that

classmate
Date _____
Page _____

explains the history of the oval portrait. Through this book, the reader learns about the painter and his young, beautiful wife, and how the painting was created. This inner story is important because it reveals the tragic events behind the life like portrait hanging in the room.

This storytelling method makes the story more engaging and suspenseful, instead of giving the full story directly, the author slowly uncovers the truth through the narrator's reading. This builds tension and mystery, and when the dark truth is finally revealed, it becomes more shocking and powerful to the reader.

e) The story is told in a descriptive style, with plenty of imagery and symbolism. which images and symbols do you find in the story?

Ans The story uses many dark and powerful images to create a scary and mysterious mood. Imagery is a literary device characterized by the use of vivid descriptive language that provides readers to create image in their mind. The old, empty castle symbolizes loneliness, danger and death. The weak candlelight represents limited understanding and the slow arrival of truth.

Several symbols are used to give deeper

meaning to the story. The oval shape of the portrait symbolizes life, completeness, and eternity, but in this story it becomes a symbol of imprisonment. It traps the woman's life and beauty inside the painting. The dark tower room ~~where~~ where the woman sits represents isolation and loss of freedom, as she is cut off from the outside world.

The portrait itself is the strongest symbol. It represents the dangerous power of art when it becomes more important than human life. It also symbolizes the thin boundary between life and death. The woman's fading health is another symbolic image of how real life slowly disappears into art.

f) What does the expression "she was dead!" mean?

Ans. The expression "she was dead!" is the most shocking and meaningful line in the story "The Oval Portrait". It means that the young woman had died at the exact moment when the painter finally completed her portrait. This line shows the tragic truth that the artist, in his obsession with art, failed to notice that his wife was slowly losing her life.

classmate
Date _____
Page _____

This expression also shows the conflict between art and life. The woman loved her husband, but she suffered because he gave all his attention to painting. His love for art became stronger than his love for her.

In a deeper sense, this line means that art stole her life. Her real beauty and life were transferred into the painting. When the painter said, "she was dead!", he finally realized the terrible price of his masterpiece.

• Reference beyond the text

a) Do you think there is life in art?

Ans Art does not have real life like people or animals, but it can feel alive because of how it shows emotions, beauty, or stories. Good art makes people feel happy, sad, or surprised, which makes the art seem like it has its own spirit or life. For example, a painting can show a smile or ~~s~~ sadness so clearly that it feels like the person in the picture is alive.

Artists put a lot of their feelings and ideas into their work, so art carries their energy. This gives art a kind of life that

~~cannot~~ connects with the viewer. Although it is not alive in a physical way, art can inspire and move people deeply, making it seem like it breathes with feelings.

So, while art is not truly alive, it can create an illusion of life that touches the heart and mind of anyone who looks at it.

b) As a thing of art nothing could be more admirable than the painting itself. Explain.

Ans. A painting is admired because it shows the artist's skill, creativity, and emotions all in one place. It captures a moment, a feeling, or a story that can last forever. This makes a good painting very special and valuable as a work of art.

In "The Oval Portrait," the painting is described as perfect and beautiful. It seems so real and alive that it amazes anyone who sees it. The artist's ability to create such a lifelike image shows his great talent and hard work.

A painting like this is admirable because it can express things words cannot. It can make viewers feel connected to the subject and understand the artist's

classmate
Date _____
Page _____

passion. That is why, as a work of art, the painting itself is something to respect and appreciate deeply.

c) A more intense look at the painting reveals the illusion. Have you noticed any such painting?

Ans. Yes, many paintings and artworks create an illusion that tricks our eyes. These paintings look very real, like photographs, or sometimes they show things that seem to move or change when we look closely. This kind of art is called realism or optical illusion art.

For example, some street artists paint pictures on roads that look like deep holes or 3D objects. When we look at them, it feels like something real is happening, but it is just paint and clever design. These paintings surprise and impress us because they show the artist's skill in creating illusions.

In museums, I have seen portraits where the eyes seem to follow you around the room. This makes the painting feel alive even though it is still. Such paintings remind us that art can create powerful illusions that change how we see the world.